

Chapter 45: When Words Finally Land

Jenny didn't sleep.

Not again.

But this time, it wasn't absence that kept her awake.

It was presence.

Austin's words didn't leave her head the way silence used to.

They stayed.

Structured.

Unmoving.

Like something placed carefully inside her thoughts and refusing to be rearranged.

"You're part of me."

She hated how easily she remembered it.

The next morning, she arrived earlier than usual.

She told herself it was coincidence.

But she didn't believe it.

Neither did Bao.

"You're early," he said immediately.

Jenny avoided his gaze.

"I woke up early."

"Mm."

That sound alone said he didn't buy it.

Austin was already there.

Same seat.

Same posture.

But something about him felt slightly more grounded now.

Not softer.

Not harder.

Just... decided.

Jenny stopped a few steps away from the counter.

He looked up.

"Morning."

She hesitated.

Then—

"Morning."

A pause.

Neither of them moved first.

That was new.

Jenny finally spoke.

"You shouldn't say things like that."

Austin tilted his head slightly.

"Which part?"

"You know which part."

He didn't deny it.

Instead, he said calmly,

"I meant it."

That made her pause.

"...That's not the issue."

"Then what is?"

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"That you say it like it's already true for both of us."

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"It is already true for me."

Silence.

That distinction again.

Always him first.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I don't know what I am for you yet."

Austin nodded.

"I know."

A pause.

"But I know what I am for you."

That made her freeze slightly.

"...And what am I for me?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then quietly—

“Someone you don’t leave easily anymore.”

Silence.

That landed too accurately.

Jenny looked away immediately.

Of course she did.

But this time, her voice was softer.

“That’s not a definition.”

“It’s a pattern,” Austin said.

Jenny frowned.

“You’re back to that word again.”

“Yes,” he said.

“Because it’s consistent.”

A pause.

“And consistency is what I trust now.”

That line felt different.

Not emotional.

Not romantic.

Something closer to commitment without naming it.

Jenny lowered her voice.

“I don’t trust how fast this is becoming something.”

Austin didn’t react defensively.

"I'm not moving fast."

Jenny looked at him.

"...It feels fast."

A pause.

Then—

"Because you're noticing it now," he said.

"I've been here longer than you've been ready to acknowledge it."

Silence.

That hit differently.

Because it implied something she hadn't fully accepted yet.

That the emotional timeline between them was not equal.

Jenny sat on the edge of a nearby chair without realizing it.

For once, her body moved before her control did.

Austin noticed.

Of course he did.

He didn't comment.

He just stayed present.

After a moment, she said quietly,

"If I say I need more time..."

Austin nodded.

"I know."

"...Will you still stay like this?"

A pause.

Then—

“Yes.”

Simple.

No conditions.

No retreat.

That simplicity unsettled her more than pressure ever did.

Jenny looked at him.

“You make it sound easy.”

“It isn’t,” he said.

A pause.

“But I’ve stopped making it dependent on ease.”

Silence.

She exhaled slowly.

“I don’t know what I’m supposed to do with you now.”

Austin met her gaze.

“You don’t have to do anything with me.”

A pause.

“You just have to stop pretending I’m not already here.”

That sentence stayed.

Heavy.

Unavoidable.

Jenny stood again.

Not because she was leaving.

Because she needed movement.

Something physical to match the internal pressure.

But she didn't walk away.

Not fully.

"You're dangerous," she said quietly.

Austin almost smiled.

Not fully.

Just enough to acknowledge it.

"I know."

A pause.

Then softer—

"But not to you."

Silence.

Jenny didn't respond.

Because she wasn't sure if that was true.

Or already becoming true.

And for the first time...

the space between them didn't feel like uncertainty.

It felt like something that had already crossed a point of return—

and was now just waiting for them to decide how to live inside it.